

Taking office in 1961, John Fitzgerald Kennedy presented himself as the leader of a new generation inspired by idealism and infused with optimism. To this day, his image endures as a symbol of hope for a better world, and his assassination in 1963 is often seen as the moment when America lost its innocence. His murder in the back of an open-top car during a visit to Dallas was the first step toward the bitter disillusionment that reached full flood during the Vietnam War.



Personal charisma

Age 43 at his inauguration, John F. Kennedy was the youngest person to win election to the presidency. He projected an image of youthful optimism and energy at a time of Cold War tension and social conflict.